. Abu’l Fazl, *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl* (completed by Inayatullah), trans. Henry Beveridge, vol. 2 (first published 1902–1939; Low Price Publications, 2017).
. Six years later, Akbar would kill a lioness, again with a sword, again single-handed.
. As must any nobleman or noblewoman of the age. Babur’s grandmother, for example, had an unwelcome male visitor stabbed to death and thrown out of the door, not batting an eyelid (Ira Mukhoty tells the story in *Daughters of the Sun: Empresses, Queens and Begums of the Mughal Empire* [Aleph, 2018]). It is a moot point whether the world has grown more or less violent over the last 400 years. Would sixteenth-century soldiers, inured to blood, be horrified, nevertheless, by the sheer scale of the carnage that nuclear bombs inflict?
. News of Humayun’s fall had arrived a few days ago; Bairam had turned his army around immediately, abandoning the march to Mankot for Delhi. Only days later, another messenger arrived. It was too late; Humayun was dead.
. Abdul Qadir Badauni, *Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh* (Selections from Histories) vol. 2, trans. W.H. Lowe (first published 1884–98; Atlantic Publishers and Distributors, 1990).
. The Mughal troops had taken over a local *eidgah*, a compound meant for prayer gatherings. Ibid.
. *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 2.
. That is, from the Prophet Muhammad himself.
. *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 1. ‘Shah Abu’l-Ma’ali traced his descent from the sayyids of Termiz. His personal beauty made the good and right-thinking look for goodness of nature, and his forwardness was tolerated on account of his courage. Consequently he became a favourite with [Humayun].’
. *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 1. It is also possible that Abul Ma’ali instigated Humayun’s trip to Qandahar by suggesting that Bairam was plotting against him. Nizamuddin writes that Humayun’s chiefs tried to sow discord between Humayun and Bairam, so much so that Humayun ordered Munim Khan to take over Qandahar as governor. ‘But Munim Khan remonstrated, and said that an expedition to Hindustan was resolved upon, and if the chief men were offended and alienated, disaffection would arise in the army. After the conquest of Hindustan that course might be pursued which the necessities of the time might require.’ See Nizamuddin Ahmad, ‘Tabakat-i Akbari’, in *The History of India, As Told by Its Own Historians*, trans. H.M. Elliot, vol. 5 (Trübner and Co., 1873).
. *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 1.
. Badauni, *Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh*, trans. W.H. Lowe.
. Ibid.
. Harbans Mukhia, *The Mughals of India* (Blackwell Publishing, 2004; Indian reprint by Wiley India, 2018).
. Abu’l Fazl, *The History of Akbar*, vol. 3, trans. W.M. Thackston (Murty Classical Library of India, Harvard University Press, 2017).
. *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 2.
. Ibid.
. Badauni, *Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh*, trans. W.H. Lowe.
. Muhammad Adil’s real name was Mubariz Khan. His assumed title, which means ‘just’, did not sit well with his subjects, apparently, who preferred to call him ‘Andhali, which means “blind”’. Ibid.
. Vincent A. Smith, *Akbar the Great Mogul, 1542–1605* (Clarendon Press, 1917).
. *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 1. Abul Fazl would have resented the comparison between Adil and Akbar.
. While Hemu was leading his army ever closer to Delhi, Sulaiman had arrived to besiege Munim Khan in Kabul. Short of both troops and provisions, Munim Khan ‘and his few starving soldiers’ made a great show of plenty when Sulaiman’s envoy came to the city, to trick him into believing